

threat level: **human**

The attack vector you can't patch.

Social Engineering Red Flags

A field guide to the moment an attack works: when a real person decides to trust.

60%

of breaches involve the human element

Verizon DBIR 2025

\$2.77B

reported losses to business email compromise in 2024

FBI IC3 2024

21 sec

median time to click a phishing link

Verizon DBIR 2024

WATCH FOR THESE

01 Urgency and pressure

Act now, this expires, do not tell anyone.
Legitimate requests survive a pause.

03 Payment that breaks the rules

Wire changes, gift cards, crypto, or new bank details that arrive by message.

05 An MFA prompt you did not start

Approving a push you did not request hands your live session to the attacker.

07 Requests to bypass process

Just this once, skip the second approver, move it to a personal channel.

02 Authority on display

A name, a title, or a logo used to make you skip the normal check.

04 A sender that almost matches

Look-alike domains, a reply-to that differs, a display name that spoofs someone you know.

06 Verify your account links

A login page reached from a message, not from your own bookmark or typed address.

08 Emotional leverage

Fear, flattery, sympathy, or a manufactured crisis that rushes your judgment.

THE ONE MOVE

The one move that beats most of them: stop and verify on a channel you chose. Call back on a known number, open the site from your own bookmark, confirm with the person directly. The attacker is counting on you not to pause.

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Sources: Verizon Data Breach Investigations Report (2024, 2025); FBI IC3 2024 Annual Report. Figures as publicly reported.

How this is made: threat level: human is an AI-assisted production. A real person researches every story, checks each claim against primary sources, and is accountable for the facts.